relations between the two countries on a new footing. In the early 1980s, he invited Prime Minister Indira Gandhi to visit Beijing. Serving diplomats were sympathetic, but Mrs Gandhi's foreign policy advisor—who had been the last ambassador in Beijing before the war—rejected the proposal, saying that the Chinese could never be trusted. 'They killed her father', were the words he used, when the gist of Deng's invitation was conveyed to him.

After Nehru's grandson, Rajiv Gandhi, took over as prime minister of India, the invitation was renewed. In December 1988, Rajiv Gandhi visited China, the first Indian leader of any substance to do so for more than thirty years. He had a ninety-minute meeting with Deng, who is said to have told him, 'You are the young. You are the future.'

In a public speech in Beijing, Rajiv Gandhi remarked that 'it is now time to look beyond the past; it is now time to look forward to the future. It is now time to restore the relationship between our countries to a level commensurate with the contribution which our civilizations made to the world, to a level commensurate with the centuries of friendship between our two countries, to a level commensurate with the contribution which today we must take together to the building of a new world order. Between us, we represent a third of humanity. There is much we can do together.'

The sentiments were Nehruvian, and indeed, the speech was most likely drafted by two scholars who had watched Nehru work firsthand. However, Rajiv Gandhi's hopefulness was called into question by some Indian commentators. A columnist in the *Statesman* noted that the territorial disputes between the two countries remained unresolved. These were, he said, 'the strongest and certainly the most important element in the connection between the two countries'. He chastised 'the myth-makers, the political pundits, the fashionable fellow-travellers, [and] the fervent promoters of Pan-Asianism' for 'working overtime to build up the case for friendship in disregard to the border …'

This scepticism was also expressed in a letter to *The Hindu* from K. Vedamurthy, who had been a close associate of Nehru's colleague-turned-